

Introductory Meeting

KF0 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

When we use the term *orientation* in Karis Fellowships, we are talking about realigning with our Creator and living within the realities of our created design. If you are in this group, you have probably been able to admit to yourself that you have deviated from the Creator and from your created design through neurosis. Sometimes the word *neurosis* is a little confusing for our generation, so in KF we use the term *misorientation* instead. Misorientation is a kind of rebellion against our Creator and our design. We have misoriented away from our true purpose and calling by trying to save the life of our idealized self. Our goal is to reorient back to God as His creatures, to learn what is pleasing to Him, and to fulfill our created purpose in this material world, which is to be in relationship with Him.

0:03 PRESENTING

In Karis Fellowships, we encourage anonymity. There is no need to share your last name, and you can even make up a name to maintain your privacy. Only you know your privacy needs, and we want to protect them as much as we wish to protect our own. Similarly, we protect those close to us by referring to them as *another KF member*, *someone I love*, or *someone who is close to me*. Referring to others in this way helps protect everyone’s privacy, and it avoids the appearance of inside knowledge or cliques. It also reminds us that in the group we each tell our own story and not the story of another. Our story is ours and ours alone.

When you are not speaking, please mute your microphone or phone. This will cut down on any background noise or echo. If you forget, the facilitator will kindly remind you to mute. It sometimes takes a little practice to be mindful about muting, so be gentle with yourself as you learn.

0:09 KARIS CIRCULATION

Karis Fellowships is an organization run completely by volunteers, but our website and the other services that we use require financial support. If you receive gifts of training from Karis Fellowships that enhance your well-being and your connection to God, return regular financial gifts to the Fellowships. By doing so, you invite more well-being and connection into your life. Your gifts say, “Thank you.” In KF, we refer to this principle as *circulation*. It is the essence of karis.

0:11 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

Since we are committed to adhering to time restraints, we will always begin our meetings on time and end on time, or before. If, however, from time to time, you need to join the group late, please call in

anyway. Although the call-in prompt asks you to immediately announce your presence, wait until the facilitator acknowledges you. If the facilitator forgets, go ahead and announce yourself when there is a pause in the meeting. If you should join the meeting and find yourself in the middle of silence, it is probably because the group is in mindfulness training. Just be patient and wait a minute for someone to start speaking again. You will know that the group is meeting because the call-in prompt will tell you how many people are gathered on the call.

0:13 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Karis Fellowships is more than an education. Over the years, we have seen that regular attendance will actually start to orient members and set them on a path toward real glory. One of our tools for orientation is the practice of mindfulness and Christian meditation. Although the words *meditation* and *mindfulness* are often used interchangeably, the practice of each has a distinct purpose. In KF, mindfulness training simply means that we train our minds and bodies to notice, without judgment, what is happening inside and around us in the moment. We define meditation as training ourselves to quiet our minds and connect with God beyond words or images. We learn to dwell alone with Him in silence and stillness. Christians have been meditating for centuries, but we have largely lost the tradition of meditation in the Protestant church. What would our worship be like if we gathered to be silent before the Lord for thirty minutes, as John reports in his Revelation?¹

Mindfulness and meditation are difficult for everyone. That is why they are called spiritual disciplines. Disciples are learners, and a discipline is something that you have to learn. It takes time to learn any new skill, and Karis Fellowships supports you in the process of learning. Think of your mind as a new puppy learning to sit still on command. Everything distracts the puppy at first; a puppy can only focus on a command for a few seconds. The trainer knows that. He doesn't punish the puppy for not doing what it is not yet trained to do. Instead, he rewards the puppy for what it tries to do. Pat yourself on the head every time you make an effort in these new skills. Your lasting reward will be the added control over your mind and emotions, which will lead to more peace, strength, and stability in your life.

You can find the mindfulness and meditation scripts from these meetings on the KF website.

Let's begin learning the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.² Follow these basic instructions as I guide you.

We start with **AWARENESS**.

Bring yourself into the present moment by adopting an appropriate posture. Sit upright, if you can, and straighten your neck. Lower your chin a little, and let your shoulders fall back naturally. Think of the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Plant the entire sole of each foot on the ground or sit cross-legged on the floor. If possible, close your eyes. *(Pause)* Now ask yourself: *What is my experience right now—in thoughts, in feelings, and in my physical sensations?* *(Repeat)* *(Pause)* Get to know yourself a little. As you breathe, acknowledge and register your experience, even if it is unwanted or uncomfortable. Notice the thoughts within your mind, your feelings, and what your body is sensing. Breathe, and simply observe for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Move to **GATHERING**.

Gently direct your full attention to your breathing—to each in-breath and each out-breath as they follow one after the other. Your breath can function as an anchor to bring you into the present moment, to help you focus your awareness, and to guide you into stillness. Observe your breathing for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

And now we will move to **EXPANDING**.

Expand the field of your awareness around your breathing so that you sense your body as a whole. Notice how your body moves with the breathing. Notice your posture. What is your face doing? Observe and breathe for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause, and gently redirect your mind back to the meeting.

The **3-Minute Breathing Space** provides a way to step out of the habitual reactions of automatic pilot mode. When events occur, a breathing space can help you thoughtfully reconnect with yourself and with God. Maintaining awareness in the moment, without making judgments, is the key skill to learn through this practice.

Begin your own daily practice this week, spending one minute on each of the three steps. Try following the instructions for the **3-Minute Breathing Space** in the morning and then again later in the day. This will help you learn to be aware of what you are experiencing in the present moment—right here, right now. You can practice this mindfulness exercise using the teaching notes to guide you, or you can download the instructions under the **Toolbox** menu on the KF website. Alternatively, you can call this meeting's playback number and follow along with the group again.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:22 KARIS CONFESSION

At each meeting, we listen to the KF Confessions to remind ourselves of what we learned in the *Neurosis and Human Growth* book study and, also, to take us beyond the study into the promise and vision that God has for each of us. There are twelve Confessions because there are twelve months. Each month we look in detail at one of the Karis Confessions.

0:24 TOOLBOX

This week we will explore how Karis Fellowships works. Let's begin with how the meetings are structured.

Each meeting is divided into the same sequence of introductions and training. Bring a copy of the **Meeting Schedule** with you to the meeting so that you can help by reading one of the introductions. During the **Toolbox** segment of the meeting, we explore integration techniques, worksheets, and practical training exercises that help us process our anxieties, conflicts, and self-hate in very practical ways. We learn to interrupt the autopilot of our neurotic solution, which drives our chronic reactions, and we train ourselves to use that same energy to make healthy choices, building the glorious life God intends for each of us.

Let's now look at five points that describe our work in Karis Fellowships.

1. *The real self is the True Self*

In the book study, we learned that our present solution for anxiety and conflicts is neurotic, or misoriented. Our neurotic solution isn't real or true, and it isn't working very well; otherwise we wouldn't be in this group. We have found ourselves on a personal identity map that says, "You are here," and we have decided that "here" is not where we want to stay. In Karis Fellowships, we hope to dismantle our misoriented development and grow into the *True Self*, which God created. Dr. Horney

talks about the *real self*, but we use the term *True Self* because this self is congruent with the truth.³ We know that God is true and that Jesus is the Way, the Truth, and the Life.⁴ As we follow the way of Jesus, we grow into our True Self, and we become the truth of who He created us to be. We learn to build a life that declares the glory of God.

2. **The *idealized self* is the *Idol Self***

In the Fellowships, we call the *idealized self* the *Idol*—I-D-O-L—or *Idol Self*. Someday you might want to go through the Bible looking at the characteristics of idols, graven images, and false gods. You may find it striking, as I did, to see the similarity between the characteristics of the idealized self and an idol. To dismantle this Idol, we must commit to the goal of learning real love.

3. **Karis Fellowships is a training program**

During the year of training, you will be introduced to many tools that will help restore your True Self. The training will feel overwhelming. Depending on your neurotic development, you will want to master it all immediately, feel chronic self-judgment, or feel rebellious and do as little as possible. Remember that you are like a puppy and can only learn at your own pace. You learn by taking small puppy steps toward developing endurance and self-management, which prepares you to take up more training in the future. You can't learn it all or know it all at once, and that's why many KF members continue to train with KF for several years.

Most of life is maintenance (Repeat), and our soul's health is no exception. You are beginning the long but very fulfilling journey toward your True Self. Once you become acquainted with your True Self, you will want to continue supporting its health. Just like engaging in regular exercise or improving the quality of your meals and sleep, the restoration of the True Self is a life-long journey into health. Your physical health will not sustain itself without consistent effort, and neither will your True Self. This impermanence is a characteristic of being a creature and not a god. Karis Fellowships gives you tools that will help you invest in your True Self for the rest of your life.

4. **Showing up**

Members of Karis Fellowships have reported that just showing up for the meetings each week has changed their lives. I would encourage you to use whichever KF tools you can during the week, but if you are an overly busy puppy or a puppy that feels frozen and overwhelmed, your first step will be to simply attend the meetings. Remember that substantial healing occurs in the real-time meetings in which we benefit from the energy of others who are presenting themselves to heal and be healed. If you miss a meeting, you can join other meetings during the week or listen to your regular meeting through the playback number provided on the KF website. Scripts and contact numbers for other meetings are also provided on the website. As a minimum, you might review the **Expanded Version** of the meeting notes.

There are so many bold commands in the Bible about love. Love is essential. Jesus taught that the greatest commandment is to love the Lord your God in every area of your life and to love your neighbor as yourself, and in Paul's first letter to the Corinthians we learn that without love we are nothing.⁵ Love is the priority Fruit of the Spirit from which all other fruit flows.⁶ In Karis Fellowships, we will learn how to love in the way that the New Testament describes.

5. **Take your work seriously**

It is God's desire that you learn to love. As you learn to love, God's love is able to flow through you to your family, to your community, and to this messed-up world. You can learn to stop being part of the

mess. By restoring your True Self, you allow God's will of love to be done through you, on earth as it is in heaven.⁷

Our prayer might go something like this:

God, my Father and Creator, I choose to begin this journey of love with You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

Before we start the sharing segment of the meeting, you might wish to have some purified drinking water available. Water helps our bodies process our experience during the meetings.

Let's talk about the **Meeting Preparation Guide** for a moment. I have a ring binder in which I store completed and blank preparation guides, KF documents, and worksheets. With a completed preparation guide, you are ready to efficiently offer your story in the meeting, and you also have a record of your own restoration. Alternatively, you can download the guides and keep a record of your recovery and progress on your computer. The DOC version will allow you to modify the document.

In the **Meeting Preparation Guide**, we use the terms *oriented* and *misoriented*. To keep things simple, I have reduced lots of Greek words down to those two basic concepts. Essentially, these Greek words express the idea of living in harmony and correspondence with God and His Creation, or not. When we are oriented, we make choices that are in harmony with God's desires and promises. Orientation is the work of the True Self. Oriented people are supported by God and connected to His resources, and they consistently produce the Fruit of the Spirit.⁸ By living their lives God's way, they contribute to the Creation and to the community. The Greek words that I have summarized as *orientation* are often translated in our Bibles as *righteousness, justice, love, faith, walking by the Spirit*, and *goodness*.

When we are misoriented, we are out of harmony with God, ourselves, and the Creation, and we actively create harm, often without realizing it. Misorientation through pride is the work of the Idol Self, and God will always oppose our pride. As a result, we sense deep down that we are not supported by God nor connected to His resources. When we lack this support and connection, we cannot consistently produce the Fruit of the Spirit in our lives—we are neurotic. The Greek words that I have bundled into the term *misorientation* are translated in our Bibles as *sin, transgression, unrighteousness, the flesh, disobedience*, etc. Basically, these words mean missing the mark, wandering from the path, stumbling, error or delusion, and failure.

The other items in the **Meeting Preparation Guide** are self-explanatory. However, thankfulness, which is at the end of the guide, is very important in the process of reorientation and is well worth highlighting here. We will see in the KF Romans study that misoriented people do not honor God, nor do they give thanks. Gratitude reminds us that we are not God. It also helps us be aware of how God is supporting us, even when our feelings are telling us a tale of woe. Gratitude is physically and spiritually beneficial. Learning to be thankful in all things is part of the reorientation process.

If you are new to the group, feel free just to listen during the sharing time. When you are ready, it is to your advantage, and it also benefits the group, if you give the gift of sharing your experience while you

train. If you wish to share, we encourage you to set a timer to remind you of the 5-minute time limitation. This is simply an opportunity to share your own work. We do not give counsel; neither do we ask for advice. When a member has finished sharing, we simply say “Thank you” to acknowledge his or her contribution.

Let’s begin our sharing.

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We encourage you to read your Bible throughout the week and look for examples of what you are learning in KF. If you have your Bible with you now, turn to the Gospel of John, chapter 17. The whole of this chapter is our text for the introductory lesson. Here, Jesus is praying for His followers. His prayer is an astounding revelation of the true glory that He has in mind for us. Before we look at the nature of this true glory, let’s review what we learned in the book study about our self-manufactured glory.

We learned that we have a neurotic need to search for glory. Our backgrounds, our conflicts about other people, our deep anxiety, our natural strengths and weaknesses, and our need for self-confidence all pressed us into seeking an imagined safe place. We then tried to make that safe place our identity; we created an Idol Self. That Idol Self can never feel safe because it is false. It is a house built on sand, but it gives us an illusion of glory.⁹ The Idol uses our powerful imagination to validate this false glory by exaggerating evidence that perpetuates our illusions and by dismissing any evidence that might call us back to reality. Chronic insecurity regarding our real attributes presses us beyond what is rational into an imagined identity characterized by superior attributes and abilities.

In our Bible passage, however, we discover that we are designed by God to grow into the true glory that He intended for us. Consequently, deep within, we are seeking the natural fulfillment of our original design. We were created to be glorious, and through revealing our glory as God’s creatures, we declare God’s glory in our own unique way. I suppose this brings us to the big question: What is glory?

In John 17, Jesus prays to His Father about the nature of our true glory, which is revealed through the dynamics of *karis*—this relationship based on mutual generosity that we are invited to enjoy. Let’s consider some of the aspects of Biblical glory that this intimate prayer reveals.

1. Glory is of primary importance

Jesus talks to the Father about glory right from the start. He wants His Father to glorify Him so that He can glorify His Father. You might ask, “What does it mean to glorify another person?” To glorify another person is to enhance their reputation in the community. Therefore, the ultimate purpose of our true glory is to enhance God’s reputation. We glorify another person when we reflect their qualities. So, when our words and actions reflect God’s character, we glorify His worth, honor, excellence, and abilities. In His prayer, Jesus asks to be revealed as a trustworthy son because He wants His life to reflect the character of God; He wants to enhance His Father’s glory. Jesus is preparing to reveal more of who God is on the cross. What attributes of God’s character will He reveal? On the cross, He will reveal the all-encompassing love that God has for His Creation. Jesus will also reveal God’s ability to manage this messed-up world and the problem of sin. Finally, He will reveal what a human being can accomplish when acting out of a pure, direct connection with God. This is glorious.

2. Glory has to do with giving

In verses 2 and 4, we see between the Father and the Son a dynamic relationship of giving, which

overflows to us in the gift of eternal life. Jesus tells the Father, “I have brought glory to You, Father, by fulfilling the work that You gave me to do.”¹⁰ The Father gave Jesus authority and, also, a glorious mission, and by fulfilling that mission, Jesus returned a gift that glorified His Father. This almost incomprehensible generosity between the Father and the Son is a demonstration of glory, and we are invited to participate in this glorious relationship of mutual giving that overflows into the lives of others.

3. Glory is revealed through joyful lives

We see in verse 10 that the lives of those whom the Father has given to Jesus declare the glory of Jesus by displaying His character. We read further in verse 13 that an integral part of this glory is joy. Jesus prays that His joy will be fulfilled in us. His joy in us is an expression of His glory. Isn't that amazing? Neuro-physicists say that our brains are hard-wired for joy.¹¹ The Bible teaches us that joy is right up there with love when God's character is revealed. Jesus is teaching us that joy is our natural habitat. Living in joy is glorious.

4. Glory is doing things God's way

In verse 14 we learn that, along with His glory, Jesus has given God's word to His followers. This is the *logos*. We can translate this Greek word as *God's way of doing things*. Jesus is our only example of a human being who has accomplished the mission God designed for him while remaining fully integrated with his True Self. Jesus gave us the great gift of showing us how to fulfill our own glory by doing things God's way. The natural result of our glory is that others can learn something about God by watching us.

5. Glory offers the potential for unity

With regard to our KF work, the particular aspect of this glory that I would like you to notice is in verse 22. Jesus affirms, “I have given to them the very same glory that You gave to Me so that they may be one just as We are one.” God gave Jesus glory, and Jesus has passed that same glory on to us. He has done this for the sake of unity, not primarily with each other but with Him and within ourselves. In Jesus, we are no longer a kingdom divided against itself, fighting to suppress the True Self and actualize the Idol Self; we are no longer at war with ourselves and at war with God.¹² Now, because of the work of Jesus Christ, we can stand unified. It is only in being unified, just as He is, that we can act with consistent power, love, and confidence in this world.

Consider revisiting this chapter and see if you can make more connections between giving, glory, unity, and love.

We might pray this very bold prayer together:

Lord Jesus, glorify me so that I might glorify You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Bring some purified water to the meetings. Water helps your body process what it is experiencing. You may also wish to take some notes on the back of your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you might start a

KF journal. Assume an alert and upright posture, whatever works for you, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

We always end our meetings with the **FAITH Process**. F-A-I-T-H is an acronym for Feelings, Awareness, Inquiry, Talk to Jesus, and Heal.

Here is our integration focus: *Consider God's generous gifts. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

F is for Feelings

As you *consider God's generous gifts*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

A is for Awareness without judgment

As you breathe and *consider God's generous gifts*, allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings and thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

I is for Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider God's generous gifts*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. Perhaps you can find unfairness or resentment in your body; perhaps hope or joy. Just explore. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

T is for Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider God's generous gifts*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* When you consider God's gifts, what story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? Do you hope for something? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath, like a sigh. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

H is for Heal

For thousands of years, human beings have had very strong feelings when they have *considered God's generous gifts*. You are also a human creature, and you are not alone in your feelings. *(Pause)* You can breathe rather than reacting and getting caught up in explanations. Breathe with compassion for our human condition, and help your body release with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

If you have completed the prerequisites for joining KF and wish to begin training in the next cycle, please register on the website under the Registration tab or email admin@karisfellowships.com for assistance. If your membership is accepted, the admin team will allow you access to the KF website where you will find the meeting days and times, call-in numbers, and various guides and worksheets. We would like to remind everyone that Karis Fellowships is a gift offered by volunteers and that no one is under any obligation.

¹ Rev. 8:1.

² Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams and John D Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

³ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁴ John 14:6.

⁵ Matt. 22:37–39; 1 Cor. 13:2.

⁶ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁷ Matt. 6:10.

⁸ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁹ Matt. 7:24–27.

¹⁰ John 17:4.

¹¹ content.time.com/time/magazine/article/0,9171,1015863-2,00.html.

¹² Matt. 12:25.